

parse lists of what was on sale automatically via software instead of by hand, even eventually taking credit card payments online instead of a handwritten check.

Before long, they had built a substantial service offering, first in the Austin area and eventually nationwide. But along the way, their product development team was always focused on scaling something that was working rather than trying to invent something that might work in the future. As a result, their development efforts involved far less waste than is typical for a venture of this kind.

It is important to contrast this with the case of a small business, in which it is routine to see the CEO, founder, president, and owner serving customers directly, one at a time. In a concierge MVP, this personalized service is not the product but a learning activity designed to test the leap-of-faith assumptions in the company's growth model. In fact, a common outcome of a concierge MVP is to invalidate the company's proposed growth model, making it clear that a different approach is needed. This can happen even if the initial MVP is profitable for the company. Without a formal growth model, many companies get caught in the trap of being satisfied with a small profitable business when a pivot (change in course or strategy) might lead to more significant growth. The only way to know is to have tested the growth model systematically with real customers.

PAY NO ATTENTION TO THE EIGHT PEOPLE BEHIND THE CURTAIN

Meet Max Ventilla and Damon Horowitz, technologists with a vision to build a new type of search software designed to answer the kinds of questions that befuddle state-of-the-art companies such as Google. Google befuddled? Think about it. Google and its peers excel at answering factual questions: What is the tallest mountain in the world? Who was the twenty-third president of the United States? But for more subjective questions, Google struggles. Ask, "What's a good place to go out for a drink after the ball game in my